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This past summer, I interned at CB2, a sister company of Crate & Barrel headquartered in Chicago, Illinois. The internship lasted ten weeks, forty hours per week, and it turned out to be far more rewarding than I could have imagined. I served as a merchandising intern for the upholstery department, which was only one of the many specialized teams within the broader merchandising division. Over the course of the summer, I contributed to a team of five and collaborated with colleagues from marketing, allocation, and finance to help support merchandising decisions.

My day-to-day responsibilities were both detail-oriented and collaborative. I conducted competitive research on our competitors' pricing, updated Excel sheets and pivot tables with daily sales data, and attended meetings across departments where I observed, asked questions, and took notes. While my placement was in merchandising, I frequently joined discussions led by other teams, which gave me a clearer understanding of how different parts of the business intersect to ensure smooth operations. This exposure taught me how interconnected merchandising is with every other department.

Beyond daily tasks, I also contributed to larger, more complex projects. One of the most significant was a color audit. At CB2, every fabric used in furniture is assigned to a "parent" color category. For example, a shade such as "ecru" might be grouped under "off-white." During my internship, CB2 launched its Fall 2025 collection, which introduced more than fifty new fabrics. Along with ensuring these fabrics were sorted into the proper parent categories, I also

reorganized the existing structure of those categories so that they were more specific. Instead of only having a broad “gray” bucket, for example, I created distinct categories for “light gray” and “dark gray.” Because of the way the data was structured, this process required me to make changes across every fabric on every piece of furniture it was used on, which meant manually updating more than three thousand SKUs. In addition, I created over four hundred new SKUs for the products introduced in the new collection. A single chair offered in fifteen different fabrics required fifteen unique SKUs, each one coded to ensure accuracy in inventory and sales tracking. I also completed an e-commerce visual display audit, where I worked with SKU data and internal systems to recode product information. This included updating care instructions, fabric composition details, and other attributes so that customers browsing online would see the most accurate and complete product information.

The most significant part of my internship was the final project I worked toward throughout the ten weeks. This project required me to propose a new custom fabric collection for CB2’s upcoming Fall 2026 launch. It culminated in a formal presentation delivered to the heads of merchandising at both CB2 and Crate & Barrel, as well as members from both teams and my entire internship cohort. For this project, I combined trend analysis, customer and competitor research, and historical sales data, while also leveraging revenue projections to guide strategic recommendations. In the end, I proposed twenty-one new fabrics with the potential to drive a projected thirty-six percent increase in seasonal sales, equating to an estimated 1.2 million dollars in revenue. It was both eye-opening and rewarding, and I felt proud of how all the pieces came together.

Over the course of the summer, I gained a variety of technical skills that strengthened my abilities as a professional. I learned how to use CB2’s internal systems, including MMT

(Merchandising Management Tool), AS400, and several programs designed specifically for the company. I also became highly proficient in Excel, which I used daily to build pivot tables, analyze data, and extract meaningful insights. Beyond technical proficiency, I developed a much deeper understanding of how merchandising functions at CB2 and how it fits into the larger organizational structure. Working on a small team meant that I was able to observe and learn from many different roles, and I felt encouraged to ask questions and seek feedback along the way. My final project, in particular, gave me a clearer picture of the extensive research, competitive analysis, and cross-departmental collaboration that goes into preparing for a new product launch.

What surprised me most about the internship had less to do with the work itself and more to do with the culture of the company. While Crate & Barrel follows a more traditional corporate structure, CB2 fostered a laid-back and collaborative environment. The office itself reflected this culture, with an open-concept design that encouraged interaction and teamwork. At the same time, both organizations maintained a relatively horizontal structure, which gave me the chance to connect with executives and senior leaders far more frequently than I expected. One of my most memorable moments came during my sixth week, when I had the opportunity to present a fabric proposal directly to the president of CB2. I had researched shearling as part of a project for my manager, and to my surprise, when it came time for the meeting with CB2's president, my manager asked if I wanted to present it myself. Although I was nervous, I shared my proposal, and it was approved. That experience was both validating and empowering, and it reinforced how grateful I was to be in such a hands-on, supportive environment.

I now feel much more confident approaching any job interview because of this experience. In just ten weeks, I not only learned the ins and outs of merchandising but also

gained exposure to marketing, planning and allocation, and finance by participating in meetings beyond my immediate department. This breadth of experience gave me a more holistic view of the retail industry and showed me how interconnected each function is in driving overall business success. At first, merchandising was challenging to grasp, but after a week or two I found my footing. By the end of the internship, I realized that I had developed strong analytical skills, becoming comfortable with numbers and data while also appreciating the creative, design-driven side of the business. I learned how to balance both the art and the science of merchandising and translate my findings into actionable, effective insights. What surprised me most was how quickly I was able to absorb and master these skills. This was reflected in a meaningful moment that came after presenting my final project, when a judge listening to my presentation commented that I “appeared to have the experience of a seasoned associate.” While incredibly flattering, this feedback also taught me something valuable about myself—I am a fast and capable learner. Knowing this has given me confidence not only in my ability to succeed in retail but also in my capacity to take on any challenge I set my mind to. Because of this internship, I know I can learn quickly, adapt, and thrive—something I will carry with me into every future role.

During my internship at CB2, I gained firsthand insights into how the EMPAC model plays out in practice, particularly in the areas of Matching, Assortment, and Convenience. For example, while working on my final project, I saw how crucial it is to align product design and fabric offerings with both customer preferences and competitor trends, which reflects the importance of effective Matching both in-store and online. My work creating and updating thousands of SKUs showed me how much thought goes into Assortment—not just offering a wide variety of couches, but ensuring that size, color, and configuration options are curated to

reflect CB2's modern aesthetic while remaining practical for different customer needs. I also learned about the challenges of Convenience, especially around delivery timelines and customization, which often required balancing customer expectations with operational realities. Seeing these dimensions from the inside helped me connect the EMPAC framework to real-world merchandising decisions, showing me how each element works together to influence the customer experience.

In closing, my internship at CB2 gave me valuable exposure to the inner workings of a modern retail organization and the chance to contribute to projects with real business impact. More than anything, it showed me the value of curiosity, adaptability, and collaboration in a fast-paced environment. These takeaways will continue to guide me as I move forward in my career and explore future opportunities in retail and beyond.